

Still choosing a degree or career? Here's how to pick one that lasts.

If your kid is still choosing, you're holding the most valuable thing in this whole process: the decision itself, still unmade.

The instinct is to ask *which field is safe?* It's the wrong question. No field is safe or doomed — every one we score holds a protected career and an exposed one under the same title. The real choice was never the field. It's the lane inside it, and whether you can reach it.

So don't pick a major. Pick a *destination* — the safe lane of a field, chosen on purpose — and a path your kid can actually walk to it. Here's how to tell the sturdy ones from the rest.

WHAT WE SCORE — THE SIX FACTORS

THREE THAT RAISE THE RISK

1.  How much of the day-to-day work can AI already do?
2.  Is the way in — the junior rung — automating away?
3.  How exposed is the high-value work as AI keeps improving?

THREE THAT LOWER IT

4.  Must it be done in person, with your hands?
5.  Does someone need a human to trust and hold responsible?
6.  Does the law require a licensed human — and does the work hit genuinely new, high-stakes calls?

SIX MOVES FOR CHOOSING WELL

1

Chase the split, not the average.

The instinct is to ask 'is this field safe?' — but no field is simply safe or doomed. Every one we score runs from a protected career to an exposed one under the same job title. The headline number hides the only choice that matters. So don't rank fields by their average. Rank them by *how good their safe lane is, and how reachable it is from where your kid stands.*

2 Weight the six factors, not the vibes.

What actually protects work is boringly consistent: it has to be done in person or with your hands; the law requires a licensed human; someone needs a person they can trust and hold responsible; the job keeps hitting genuinely new, high-stakes situations. Choose *toward* those and away from anything that reduces cleanly to a screen. A gut feeling that a field ‘seems future-proof’ is worth nothing next to which of those six boxes it actually ticks.

3 Aim at a license where one exists.

The single most durable moat we score is a legal one: the CPA signature, the PE stamp, the medical license, the bar. Software can do the work, but it cannot *hold the license* — so the licensed lane of a field is almost always its safe one. If a field has that lane, aim the whole plan at it from the first course, not as an afterthought late on.

4 Buy optionality, not one perfect bet.

Nothing is AI-proof forever, so don’t choose as if one path is. Prefer a field whose safe lane is *wide* and whose skills *travel* — one that survives being wrong about the details — over a narrow bet that only pays off if the next ten years go exactly to plan. Flexibility is the hedge you buy at the moment of choosing, and it’s cheap here and expensive later.

5 Check the on-ramp, not just the destination.

Some of the most exposed work in the whole index is the *entry rung* of otherwise-safe fields — the junior analyst, the first-year associate, the entry coder. A safe senior destination with an on-ramp that’s automating out is a trap: you can see where to end up and have no way to start. Weigh how someone actually breaks in, not only where the field lands at the top.

6 Choose the kid, not the trend.

The best path on paper is worthless if it’s a lane your kid will quietly hate and quit. Fit compounds; forced fit doesn’t. Match their real temperament to the actual work of the safe lane — the day-to-day, not the job title — because the person who stays and gets good is the one who ends up protected.

Before you commit

Six moves are the mindset. Here's the shortlist to run before your kid signs up for anything.

- ☐ **Shortlist two or three fields** — and for each, write down its safe lane and its exposed lane. If you can't name both, you don't know the field well enough yet.
- ☐ **Score each safe lane on the six factors.** License? Hands or in-person? Human trust and accountability? Genuinely novel, high-stakes calls? The more yeses, the sturdier the lane.
- ☐ **Trace the on-ramp.** How does someone actually reach that safe lane — and is the entry rung along the way automating? A destination you can't get to doesn't count.
- ☐ **Talk to someone in the safe lane** — not a recruiter, not an admissions office. Ask what the work really is, and where they think it's going.
- ☐ **Pick the lane that fits the kid, not just the market.** The durable choice is the one they'll be good at and stay in.

The scores get you to the right shortlist. They can't make the final call — that turns on *which* exact track, how durable its protection really is, and whether the specific program actually delivers it. That's what the **Career Value Guide** is for. But choose at the level of the lane, not the label, and you've already dodged the most expensive mistake there is.

Get the **Career Value Guide — Planning Edition** for the one or two careers that matter most: every track scored, the safe-versus-exposed split, the routes in, a program checklist, and the questions to ask admissions.

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